

Hist 3100

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Proposal Title: Jell-O and Gender: How Changing Technology Affected the Social Role of the 1950's Housewife

Period and Place: 1950s United States

Languages: English

Type of History: Social

The Problem

Industrialization in the post-World War II era changed the social scenes of millions of Americans, from the shift in the workplace towards manufacturing, to the grocery store carrying hundreds of new products, to the environment changing rapidly around them. The problem of what is known about this industrialization is that there is a massive group excluded from the conversation, that being housewives. A lot of people, when asked how a housewives role changed after World War II, will give an answer about how they had access to new technology like gas ovens and vacuum cleaners. This is not untrue, but it does not adequately cover the topic. These answers talk about how the housewife's role changed as a consumer, or as a worker, but not necessarily what her roles in her social circles were. This is a broad problem, so it can be narrowed down further. Looking at it through the lens of something so new and modern for a housewife, it would have been an unthinkable product to someone one hundred years before: powdered gelatin mix. How did Jell-O and other new industrial culinary technologies shape the social roles and expectations of an average, middle class, post-war housewife?

Historical Background

In the pre-world war era United States, multigenerational living was the most common family structure. After World War II, the US congress passed the G.I. Bill, which gave war veterans certain privileges to help them get a higher education, medical support, and most importantly in this context, suburban housing.¹ The emergence of suburban housing led to the ideal of the nuclear family, because young men and their wives did not have to live with their parents and grandparents anymore with such affordable housing opportunities.² In addition to less adults per household, more men were joining the workforce outside of the home, meaning that the housewife now had to do every chore and piece of domestic labor on her own.³

Although there was less human labor involved, the emergence of factories and mass production meant that there were now hundreds of new tools to assist with the upkeep of a house. One of these new tools was widespread residential refrigeration, which was first patented in 1915 as an icebox.⁴ With refrigeration, making gelatin based desserts became much more accessible to the public. Beforehand, gelatin desserts were a luxury for the people who could afford to have the gelatin extracted from animal bones, flavored with fresh fruits, and cooled down enough to be firm.⁵ That last step was the most expensive, because keeping things cold before fridges and iceboxes was a massive struggle. On top of this, in the nineteenth century, there was an emerging gelatin manufacturer making a powdered gelatin product, whereas before gelatin was sold in massive sheets that had to be purified from other residues.⁶ This all meant more accessible gelatin desserts. Additionally, refrigeration was not only for the home but for transportation and companies as well. Grocery stores could now get fresh produce faster, keep it fresh in the

¹ [Archive.Gov](https://www.archives.gov/milestone-documents/servicemens-readjustment-act) "Servicemen's Readjustment Act." June 22, 1944.

<https://www.archives.gov/milestone-documents/servicemens-readjustment-act>

² Steven Ruggles, "The Decline of Intergenerational Coresidence in the United States, 1850 to 2000," *National Library of Medicine*, no. 72 (2007), <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC3090139>

³ Ruth Schwartz Cowan, *More Work for Mother* (Basic Books, 1983), 67.

⁴ Fred W. Wolf, refrigerating apparatus. Patent issued January 26, 1915.

⁵ Mary F Henderson, *Practical cooking and dinner giving* (Harper & Brothers, 1877), 290.

⁶ Peter Cooper, improvement in the preparation of portable gelatin. Patent issued June 20, 1845.

transportation process, and have it stay good for longer on the shelves. This globalized refrigeration and movement meant that a woman in the United States could have more variety in her groceries for cheaper, even getting fresh fruits and vegetables when they aren't in season, all because the cost of transportation went down and the effectiveness of it went up.

However, even if technology was progressing forward, gender norms were not. Due to the Cold War,⁷ men coming home and wanting to work the jobs that women had worked during WWII,⁸ and the risk of social ostracization,⁹ women of middle and upper classes did not have much of a choice but to be a housewife. This fact has exceptions, of course. Low class families and households of single mothers often had to have the matriarch of the family working, but if the family could afford to keep her home, then she usually stayed there as a housewife.¹⁰

All three of these facts: the nuclear family structure becoming the social standard, the mass industrialization of food and the technology to upkeep the production of it, and the restrictive gender roles in the upper and middle class, all lead to a shift in the domestic labor expectations of the 1950s housewife. Now, the standard was that she can do all the housework without help, that she should not complain about her work due to how "easy" new technology has made her job, and that she will always stay being the ideal housewife, with a perfectly done up home, and a fancy plate of Jell-O.

Historiographical Review

In scholarship about the housewife, there are two main groups that come forward. The first group focuses on work at the house: these writings talk at length about how housework itself changed over time and how the expectations of women's work changed with it. The second

⁷ Elaine Tyler May, *Homeward Bound: American Families in the Cold War Era* (Basic Books, 1988),

⁸ Ellen Carol Dubois and Lynn Dumenil, *Through Women's eyes: An American History with Documents* (Bedford/St. Martin's, 2016), 503.

⁹ Cowen, *More Work For Mother*, 203.

¹⁰ Robert S. Lynd and Helen Merrell Lynd, *Middletown: A Study in American Culture* (1929), 27.

group focuses on work in the mind: works that emphasize the gender roles themselves and the ideology, ambivalence, and contradictions behind them. No matter which group the scholar's work falls into, all of them agree that these gender roles from the post-war era are obsolete, and even perhaps never needed in the first place. Yet it is important to make the distinction between these two groups, because while they agree in some regards, they often differ in the methods and arguments they use.

Placed squarely in the first group is Ruth Schwartz Cowan's 1983 book *More Work for Mother*. In the book, Cowan describes the process of change that housewives underwent from preindustrial times all the way into the post war era, including the change for technology, chores, and gender norms. Her work states that new technology was not the cause for changing gender norms, but rather a catalyst in the types of works that had to be done.¹¹ The new way of working then became so common for people that it cemented itself into a new set of gender roles. One of her main methods she uses to construct her argument is to actually look at the failed versions of both modern technologies and social norms. By looking at pipelines that never happened, she can better prove the cause and effect relationship between technology and housework.

In the same vein, Sandy Isenstadt a decade later, in her article "Visions of Plenty: Refrigerators in America around 1950," argues that refrigeration specifically changed the work done by housewives in the way that it promoted both overconsumption and capitalist mindsets, while also creating a culture that purposefully hides that work behind that overconsumption. In order to explain this argument, Isenstadt talks about the shift in advertising of refrigerators. When refrigeration first became widely available, it was marketed as a miracle of modernization and wealth. Though, as time went on, the message in the marketing shifted to show fridges as a

¹¹ Cowan, *More Work for Mother* (Basic Books, 1983), 209.

staple tool in the kitchen rather than a luxury.¹² Even more than this, refrigerators were consistently advertised as a tool for leisure time, but did not actually lessen the burden of housework. Isenstadt explains, “The genius of these advertisements was in the recognition that displaying leisure meant concealing labor.”¹³ This quote shows off Isenstadt’s method of dissecting marketing done towards homeowners to understand the greater social ideology of the time, while also explaining the cyclical relationship between hiding labor of overconsumption while also promoting the mindset of it.

Another piece of writing that examines a specific piece of technology and domestic labor is Lynn Spigel’s book *Made for TV*.¹⁴ While not talking specifically about food-technology and instead entertainment technology, it sheds a fascinating light on the fact that a housewife’s work time and leisure time were often the same thing, with TV becoming an integrated part of her work day. Spigel claims that the housewife’s leisure time was not spent relaxing, like her husband’s time might have been. The husband would have been able to sit down at the TV and relax without worrying about the work at home, which was only possible due to the housewife’s work. On the other hand, her leisure was only possible through the constant work and upkeep she had to do. Spigel proves this theory by discussing the various ways that television catered to men and women’s social spheres differently, for example, playing “women’s” shows during the day when a housewife would have the house to herself and “men’s” shows at night when a husband would be coming home from work.

While both Isenstadt and Spigel focus on how specific technology interacted with a preexisting social norm for middle class women, Cowen more specifically looks at how

¹² Sandy Isenstadt, “Visions of Plenty: Refrigerators in America around 1950,” *Journal of Design History*, no. 4 (1998): 311-321.

¹³ Isenstadt, “Visions of Plenty,” 314.

¹⁴ Lynn Spigel, *Make Room for TV* (University of Chicago Press, 1992), 74.

emerging technology helped form that same social norm. However, all three of these works collide on a central point: housework was changing, and so were the expectations around that work. On the flip side of this, expectations were also shifting for all women, housewives or not, to follow the gender norms established by the people who were in the housewife role.

Within the second group, that of work in the mind, Betty Frieden in 1963 kicked off a storm using her book *The Feminine Mystique*. Frieden adamantly told women to break away from the figure of the housewife, and encouraged modern feminists to leave their at-home sisters behind. She also said to abandon the idea of a “happy housewife” mythos, and that the arduous labor of housework should be de-glorified.¹⁵ Lesley Johnson, however, does not agree with Frieden’s ideology. Moving forward in time to the year 2000 for her article, “‘Revolutions Are Not Made By Down-Trodden Housewives.’ Feminism and the Housewife,”¹⁶ Johnson argues with Frieden. She says that the “myth of the happy housewife” that Frieden bases her argument on was itself a myth, and that there was no single, homogenous messaging for housewives to be happy and working. Johnson also brings up the point that housewives should not be excluded from feminism, and the non-working woman is something that a lot of people want to be, not something to just leave behind. One argument she uses is that, counter to what some second wave feminist writers said, not every single woman wants to do the exact same jobs as men, and that they should not have to in order to be accepted by their feminist peers. In the perceived “feminist prehistory,” women were barred from this option altogether, but in Johnson’s time and perspective, the opposite became true as women were told to escape the past’s shackles.¹⁷ Instead of the liberation that was promised, however, it seems that the same women that were outcasted

¹⁵ This is what Lesley Johnson claims Betty Frieden was saying, paraphrased.

¹⁶ Lesley Johnson, “‘Revolutions are not made by down-trodden housewives.’ Feminism and the Housewife,” *Australian Feminist Studies*, no. 32 (2000): 237-248.

¹⁷ Johnson, “Feminism and the Housewife,” 242.

before were now just ostracizing housewives from the feminist movement all together. Much of her method in the essay revolves around the idea of a “good enough feminist,” a term meaning a woman who does not attempt to liberate herself or others from the patriarchy because she sees herself as never being able to reach the new “superwoman” standard set by certain feminists. These women did not feel liberated by the second wave feminist movement, but rather they felt a modern, impossible standard placed on them. Johnson uses this term in her method of debunking Frieden’s myth by showing the aftereffects of Frieden’s writing, and how it led to the “good enough feminist”

In the 1999 article, “The Way to a Man's Heart: Gender Roles, Domestic Ideology, and Cookbooks in the 1950s,”¹⁸ Jessamyn Neuhaus also argues against Betty Frieden’s “happy housewives” myth. Using cookbooks, she describes that the way that media and house guides expressed gender norms and roles was actually due to the fact that no one really believed in them to the extent that Frieden claimed. Neuhaus says near the end of her essay, “The necessity of claiming authority renders authority unstable.”¹⁹ In this context, it meant that the authorities that stated gender roles over and over again (cookbooks, in this case) did so as a means to try and force the roles into existence. This didn’t work, since it left cracks in the logic that would leave the gender roles open to being questioned. Using this logic, Neuhaus states that there were people questioning and fighting back against the gender norms of the time, and that the “happy housewife myth” was, again, a myth in itself.

In my own writing, I want to examine how the group of work in the mind interacted with the group of work at the house. Looking specifically through the lens of food-based technology, how did new styles of housework affect the ideology of feminist housewives? I want to analyse

¹⁸ Jessamyn Neuhaus, “The Way to a Man's Heart: Gender Roles, Domestic Ideology, and Cookbooks in the 1950s,” *Journal of Social History*, no. 3 (1999): 529-555.

¹⁹ Neuhaus, “The Way to a Man's Heart,” 547.

three generations for this part, in order to compare and contrast the impacts: the generation of second wave feminism, to understand the immediate backlash against the specific ideologies of this time; the generation that grew up during or shortly after the fall of the Soviet Union, to see how a larger cultural shift moving away from red-scare ideology affected the perceived gendered social roles; and finally, the modern-day generation, especially those that preach or push the idea of going back to “trad wife” roles, since the idealized past they preach is based on the time period and social roles that I am discussing.²⁰

Significance

The move of the family to the social style of the nuclear household in the 1950s United States was a result of changing technology available to the average citizen. These technologies as well as the social move itself is present in most modern day-to-day household living, but especially prevalent in the kitchen, where the housewife of the 1950s was abandoned. Therefore, to understand today’s division of labor based on sex, especially the conservative backlash ideology that women should leave the professional workforce to perform labor at home, it’s crucial to look at how technology and capitalist consequences affected the precursors of today’s social scene.²¹ Dissecting the trad wife of today starts with the culinary arts and kitchens of the past.

Methods and Sources

Questions:

My main question for this project is: how did emerging culinary technology in 1950s America change the social roles and expectations of the middle class housewife, compared to the

²⁰“Trad wife” refers to women who follow and preach a type of right-wing ideology about returning to a theoretical time of conservative values and women being subservient to their husbands.

²¹In the online article by Rebecca Heiner, “Women’s Influence in the Home: Beneficial or Political Propaganda?” published by the recognized hate group *United Families International*, Heiner grossly misleads the reader as she preaches the conservative backlash ideology that is explained here.

previous couple generations? I want to use Jell-O as the main case study for this, and the lens to look at the topic through. The sub questions I will be addressing are: what was the role of housewives in the kitchen before the post-war era? How was the dominant social media (advertisements, magazines, etc) influencing the expectations for housewives? What defined the middle class in 1950s America, and why was it separate from the lower and upper classes? These questions are all social and cultural history based because I'm looking at how people in small groups, aka families, interacted with each other, and how the larger social culture influenced these small groups through means such as television, cookbooks, and other mass media.

Primary Sources:

The first primary source I will use is *Betty Crocker's Picture Cookbook*.²² This source is accessible in Marriott Library Special Collections, and can be requested for access on the library's website. Betty Crocker was a fictional character made up by the General Mills company, and was mostly developed by a woman named Marjorie Husted. Still, the character was widely influential across America for multiple decades, and her cook book will help me answer the question about how the dominant social scene influenced the everyday culinary life of the housewife. The main limitation I see with this source is that, while it will tell me a lot about an ideal version of housewives, I'm unsure if it will tell me much at all about the realistic housewife living in this time. If I remember to account for the book's bias, I will have an easier time deciphering fact from fiction, but I must keep it in mind.

The next primary source I want to use will be an interview with Morrissa Rich, my grandmother.²³ She was a housewife and mother of eight children starting in the late 1960s. She also commonly hosts, what she calls, "Jell-O parties," with a group of older women like her who

²² Betty Crocker, *Betty Crocker's Picture Cook Book* (1950).

²³ Morrissa Rich, interview with author, not yet held.

all bring plates of Jell-O that either they would make as housewives or that their own mothers would make for them. Rich has given me permission to join during the next party and record the various stories from this group, on top of the interview she has promised me. These interviews will help me answer multiple questions about my topic, such as how the expectations of these former housewives changed from what they observed in their own mothers, and how the divide between classes affected social roles. Both the individual interview with Morrissa Rich and the larger discussion with the “Jell-O party” have glaring limitations. The age of these women come to mind first, because since the 1950s happened so long ago, they might misremember details about their families or their own lives. I will have to take in a lot of facts with a grain of salt. Another limitation is that, as a younger interviewer who does not know a lot of these women very well, they might not trust me with harder details. Almost the same problem appears with the individual meeting with Rich, since she may be hesitant to tell her own grandchild certain facts that happened. If I can create a trusting environment with both Rich and the group, I may be able to get a more accurate telling of their stories.

The last primary source I want to use for this project is a transcription of a meeting between market psychologist Dr. Dichter and at least one advertiser for General Foods.²⁴ This document will give a large helping hand in answering the question of how the mass social media scene influenced housewife expectation and ideology, because it is a memo for how to do exactly that in order to sell more boxes of instant Jell-O. The biggest downside of the article is that it is written by men, for other men. This is important because, while it talks about housewives and how to theoretically get the group to perform an action, it is critically not *about* housewives, it is about the *audience* of housewives. The document is very far removed from the social role of a real person, but it remains an interesting look into the idealized role of an imaginary person.

²⁴ Ernest Dichter, *Memo re: Jello*, memorandum, Nov 12 1951.

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